

lot for Apple's design. The screens on the 5.5G iPod Classics somehow seem slightly bigger than their predecessors, and definitely brighter. The Classic utilises the same kind of chromed rear that the Nano and Touch do. A neat feature in the Classic and the Nano is the scroll. Previously, you would need to scroll through tracks alphabetically, so getting to a track that starts with, say, R would be a pain. Now, once you do a couple of fast scrolls, an alphabet is displayed and the scroll list now becomes alphabetical—scroll through the alphabets to get to the one you want, and find your track from there. A neat feature, and one that people who use the colossal storage options provided will fully utilise.

Performance

The Creative Zen Vision W is a superb music player—a fact which became apparent just a few minutes into our MP3 tests. It's even better than the iPod Classic, which is a superb PMP for music in its own right. Once again, when you're talking about brilliant PMPs, a few points of difference is hardly a big thing, but the fact is that the Zen Vision W is one heck of a PMP—it scored well because of its superb screen, which made movie watching and navigation a fun-filled affair. The Cowon A3 is another excellent video player; in fact, the slightly smaller screen is, if anything, even crisper than the Vision W. We tried watching a 720p movie on the A3, and were blown away by the extent of immersion that such a small screen can bring.

In comparison, the two iPod Classics don't seem to make as

big a splash with their diminutive 2.5-inch screens, but make no mistake, they are potent video oriented PMPs as well—it's just that their aural roots

performance—there's no comparison even between it and the cheaper D2, which is noticeably superior in the music quality department.



Creative Zen Vision W
Pocket Theatre

are a little more evident. Musically, the Vision W scores slightly more due to its very strong mids and vocals, both of which are the most important component of any genre of music and usually the highlight of any track. The iPod Classic rules the high frequencies where the detailing is very close to the iPod Touch. The Touch and the Nano are an extra inch better than the iPod Classic for music, and both are also better at mid-range frequencies than the Cowon D2 and the Vision W.

The Cowon A3 takes a back-stage when it comes to sonic

Conclusion

The best video performance would have to go to the Cowon A3—a brilliant screen, very good music performance, and a very decent all rounder to boot. The Creative Zen Vision W occupies the pinnacle of the audio tests, an outstanding product, considering that the other Creative products didn't make such a splash. But the Zen Vision W is costly, and at Rs 29,999, it's nearly double the price of the Apple iPod Classic, which has 98 per cent of its musical capabilities, 40 per cent of its video capabilities, nearly the same features, and half the price (Rs 15,500). Then there's the small matter of nearly thrice the storage space. For its brilliant all round capabilities, we're awarding our *Best Buy* to Apple's iPod Classic 80 GB. It's also a brilliant music player for the price—go with this if you want a great looking, excellent sounding, feature rich, and large capacity PMP.

If you're looking for a colossal amount of storage, you may consider its older brother—the iPod Classic 160 GB. For video, go with the 30 GB version of the Cowon A3—it's available at three fourths the price of the Vision W. ■

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